



FREEDOM AND DISSENT

“Is India forgetting its own narrative of openness?”

SALMAN RUSHDIE AUTHOR

One of my favourite moments in contemporary literature comes from the American novelist and Nobel Laureate Saul Bellow's novel *The Dean's December*. In this novel, an American academic, Dean Albert Corde of the University of Chicago, at one point visits Romania—his wife is Romanian, and they visit in winter on family business. This is of course Romania long before the fall of Communism, Ceausescu's Romania, an alarming country, restricted and bleak. A moment comes when Corde is standing at a window of his wife's family's apartment, looking out at a frost-whitened park. He hears a dog begin to bark in the distance. The dog barks on and on. On and on. And because this is a dog in a Saul Bellow novel, it is necessary for the Dean to speculate on what the dog means. He decides that the interminable barking is the dog's protest against “the limitations of dog experience”, and that what the dog is trying to say is, “For God's sake, open the universe a little more.”

Open the universe a little more. I remember that when I read that sentence, I immediately thought, “That's as good a description of the purpose and nature of art as I've ever heard.” This is what all artists—verbal, visual, musical, dramatic, cinematic—strive to do, and the degree to which they succeed depends upon their individual talents. The great artist can make the universe feel greatly enlarged, the lesser artist must settle for less, the bad artist fails in the attempt, but all art wants to push against boundaries, and to increase, by some small amount, the sum total of what it is possible to imagine, to think, to know, to feel, and therefore, finally, to become and be.

I have taken inspiration all my life from the liberal and open-minded culture into which I was born, the infinitely plural and endlessly stimulating world of post-Independence India. My family played a large part in shaping my way of thinking. My father's people lived for several generations in the famous Old Delhi mohalla of Ballimaran, the Ballimaran of Mirza Ghalib, and my father grew up with poetry filling his head. My family's name was not “Rushdie” then—my paternal grandfather was named

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